Memorandum

To: Incoming DOT Commissioner

From: Max McLoughlin, Hunter College MUP Student

Date: 4 November 2025

Subject: 34 Street Busway Enhancement

Introduction:

This memo serves as a recommendation to double down on the existing commitment for turning 34th Street in Manhattan into a busway, and advocates for **full bus rapid transit** according to the Bus Rapid Transit Standard along the entirety of the corridor with a dedicated right of way, proper station treatments, and full signal priority. 34 Street requires a more intense treatment than 14 Street, and political opposition necessitates that this project is successful for the future improvement of transit in New York City.

Context:

The bus routes on 34 Street, M34/34A, are the third slowest in the city, and the 14 Street project brought success to similar delay-prone routes on 14 Street. The currently proposed solution would span from 3 Av to 9 Av, and would allow buses and trucks, as well as local access for vehicles so long as they turn off 34 St at the first available intersection.

Improving bus transit on 34 Street is a part of the Adams Administration's "Connecting to the Core" initiative, which is meant to increase access to Midtown without a car. The busway project is in conjunction with rezonings and congestion pricing in attempt to reduce car use and densify development in Midtown.[1]

As seen in the timeline, this project is **politically fraught** and will miss its initial deadline:

05/25: DOT announced a proposal for the conversion of 34 St to a busway like 14 St.[2]
07/25: Adams administration suddenly pauses project after community board approval.[3]
08/25: Adams issues statement of approval for Midtown South rezoning including busway.[4]
10/25: FHWA (Trump) admin demand pause on busway implementation.[5]
12/25: Original targeted completion date.

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1. "NYC DOT Proposes Busway for 34th Street in Manhattan." NYC DOT.
2. "NYC DOT Proposes Busway for 34th Street in Manhattan." NYC DOT.
3. Colon, Dave. "Anti-Miracle On 34th Street: Adams Administration Pauses Work On 34th Street Busway - Streetsblog New York City." July 3, 2025.
4. Colon, Dave. "It's Back! 34th Street Busway Revived In Midtown Rezoning Deal - Streetsblog New York City." August 6, 2025.
5. Gannon, Devin. City Halts 34th Street Busway after Threats from Trump. October 20, 2025.

Recommendation:

Given the current pause on implementation, and the fact that physical work hadn't begun, the DOT **must redesign the busway to meet the Bus Rapid Transit Standard** to ensure that **significant speed and reliability improvements** are made to the bus routes on 34 St.

Required characteristics of recommended BRT corridor as defined by the BRT Standard[6]:

- Fully dedicated right of way
- Enhanced signal Priority
- Proper station treatment (level boarding, fare gates, all door boarding)

Discussion:

To support this recommendation, this discussion contains data on the existing traffic, connectivity, and demographics of the corridor, as well as comparison to the 14 Street corridor, and other considerations.

Current Traffic Conditions/Congestion:

From the material provided by the current DOT[7], it is evident that they realize the need for increased speed and capacity on 34th Street. Here is some summarized data to magnify the traffic congestion on the corridor.

- Average weekday peak hour bus speed is **5 mph**, can be as low as **3 mph**
    - The average healthy adult walks 3 mph
- **~28,000 daily bus riders** (M34/34A)
- At 6th Ave, we observed more traffic in the **Eastbound direction**
- 15,000 Annual Average Daily Travel **(AADT)[8]**
    - Field observation revealed ~1.75 passengers per vehicle
    - **~26,000 passengers per day**

Clearly, the corridor is choked with traffic, making buses travel at a pace that is **slower than walking**. In addition, the **current bus capacity is greater** than the AADT of the corridor. To further support this argument, field interviews revealed that among bus riders, speed and reliability were the top complaint. This emphasizes the need for a more efficient method of traversing the corridor, as the current setup isn't sufficient.

Now that it is established why we must address the bus speeds on this corridor, it will be stated why 34 Street must go beyond 14 Street's busway design to achieve real Bus Rapid Transit, as established by the BRT Standard.

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6. Institute for Transportation and Development Policy. "The BRT Standard."
7. "34th Street Enhanced Bus Priority." Community Board 5 Transportation & Environment Committee, May 19, 2025.
8. NYS DOT Traffic Data. "W 34TH ST from EIGHTH AVE to FIFTH AVE."

Transit Connections:
The corridor has **~220,000 daily subway** riders, and **630,000 daily commuter/intercity rail** riders[9]. In addition, this corridor allows almost all subway riders, as well as many Manhattan bus and ferry riders to access key destinations such as The Empire State Building, Madison Square Garden, Penn Station, Hudson Yards, and The Javits Center with at most one subway to bus transfer.

34th Street is arguably the most significant crosstown corridor in the city that is not served by rapid transit. In addition to its connectivity, the corridor has significant origin/destination transit demand.

Local Demographics/Destinations[10]:
The corridor has a sufficient density of homes, jobs and attractions to warrant rapid transit without the consideration of connectivity mentioned above. In addition, the recent rezoning of Midtown South is estimated to **add 10,000 homes[11]**.

- The surrounding 30 blocks to 34th St Herald Sq. contain a population of **~8000**
- Approximately **70,000** people live in the census tracts within a 10 min walk of 34 St
- The East Side of 34th St is among the **densest population below Central Park**
- **100,000 office workers** enter the 34th St district daily
- **175 department stores**, specialty shops, and national chain flagships
- **40,000 housing units,** with 17% growth since 2010

Direct Comparison to 14 St:
A direct comparison reveals that the bus transit need is more significant on 34 Street than 14 Street. It nearly matches 14 Street in terms of local demand and goes far beyond in terms of transit connectivity potential because of its lack of a crosstown subway line and the oversized significance of the transit nodes on the corridor. In addition, it contains tourist and entertainment destinations that draw visitors from around the city and around the world.

Condition	**34 Street**	**14 Street**
Existing Subway Line	NO	YES (L Train)
Busiest Passenger Rail Sta.	YES (Penn Station)	NO
Interstate Ferry Terminal	YES (34 St & East River)	NO
Population (Future)	80k-90k (70k current + 10k-20k planned) residents	~100k residents
Traffic Pre-Busway AADT	~15,000 vehicles[12]	~13,500 vehicles

9. MTA. "Subway and Bus Ridership for 2024."
10. U.S. Census Bureau, Total Population, 2020. Prepared by Social Explorer.
11. Colon, Dave. "It's Back! 34th Street Busway Revived In Midtown Rezoning Deal - Streetsblog New York City."
12. NYS DOT Traffic Data. "W 34TH ST from EIGHTH AVE to FIFTH AVE."

Why the Bus Rapid Transit Standard?

One of the most important criteria of the BRT Standard is a **dedicated right of way**[13]. It explains that "dedicated lanes matter the most in heavily congested areas where it is harder to repurpose mixed-traffic lanes as a busway."[14] 34 Street's location in Midtown Manhattan leaves it very susceptible to traffic and gridlock. Not only does the street connect many transit methods, but it also connects significant roads and highways for cars. Without a dedicated right of way, we will miss out on the potential for the most significant time savings.

In addition to the right of way, **alignment**[15] must also be prioritized. This will allow bus traffic to flow smoothly, while providing separated access to the curb for vehicles. Although the entire corridor may not be wide enough for center running bus lanes with two lanes on each side for loading and access, almost the entire corridor is 5 lanes wide, which should allow for a two-way busway on the edge of a newly transformed one-way local access street. At its narrowest, the street is 4 lanes, and these areas are already "no stopping", so there will be little-to-no reduction of curb access.

Lastly, we will evaluate the three remaining criteria of "BRT Basics".

- **Intersection Treatment**[16]**:** There is currently turn restrictions in place, which helps to reduce delays. We will go further to enhance signal priority so that buses may proceed through as many lights as possible without delay.
- **Platform Level Boarding**[17]**:** This will be achieved through a cohesive station approach, that will also include the next BRT Basic. This will reduce the dwell time of the buses and ensure quicker boarding for passengers with accessibility considerations.
- **Off-board Fare Collection**[18]**:** The BRT stations will provide fare gates if necessary. This will also help to reduce dwell times by enabling all door boarding and removing the delay of getting a payment method out for collection.
    - Note: At the time of this writing, free fares are being explored in NYC. If this is accomplished, then there is no need for fare gates.

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13. Institute for Transportation and Development Policy. "The BRT Standard." 35.
14. Institute for Transportation and Development Policy. "The BRT Standard." 35.
15. Institute for Transportation and Development Policy. "The BRT Standard." 37.
16. Institute for Transportation and Development Policy. "The BRT Standard." 45.
17. Institute for Transportation and Development Policy. "The BRT Standard." 47.
18. Institute for Transportation and Development Policy. "The BRT Standard." 43.

Further Discussion:
In addition to the above analysis, in-person data gathering revealed the frequency of bus impediments. There was a notable amount of double parking for loading/unloading, taxicabs, and police vehicles, as well as cars stuck in the intersection "blocking the box". These impediments will persist if a busway like 14 Street is pursued. Therefore, pursuing a dedicated right of way that completely separates local traffic from the bus operations is necessary.

It is also crucial that the dedicated right of way is present along the entire corridor. The eastern part contains large interchanges with the Queens Midtown Tunnel and the FDR Drive, and the western part contains intersections with Dyer Ave (access to Lincoln Tunnel) and the West Side Highway. If the corridor is only hardened from 3 Av to 9 Av, speed and reliability will still be subject to impact by traffic near these chokepoints, all which are outside of the proposed corridor.

Political Necessity:
This project has become very political, even though the underlying data (as presented here), is very strong. It is not only controversial in New York, with groups having similar opinions to the busway as they do to Congestion Pricing, but it has become politicized on a national scale.

Along with other actions taken by the Trump administration, this situation is a microcosm of the broader pro-transit and anti-transit/pro-car tensions that are felt in our city and across the nation. Transit detractors will be eagle-eyed in their criticisms, and therefore we must ensure that the 34 Street bus solution is as complete and successful as possible. As stated above, the best way to do that is to ensure the solution adheres to the BRT Standard.

Conclusion:

It is imperative that we utilize the delay of the 34 St busway to introduce proper Bus Rapid Transit to the entire corridor to **maximize the speed, reliability and connectivity** of the 34 St corridor. The corridor has significant connection to mass transit, commuter rail, ferries, and intercity rail; dense housing and planned development; world-class entertainment, shopping and office space; as well as New York's most iconic tourist attractions.

It is obvious that this corridor is currently in need of a redesign, and that the corridor requires more drastic measures than 14 Street. Due to significant pressure from political opponents, this project needs to be successful with no room for doubt. Without a design that follows the BRT Standard, this project will not meet its full potential to achieve **significant time savings, reduced subway crowding, and provide a more accessible city** to everyone, not just drivers.

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